THE BASES FOR A MISSIOLOGICAL DECISION MAKING FRAMEWORK

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by Luis Bush

The methodology of assessing missiological decision making begins with the biblical basis for understanding God's mandate to his servants. Though there are other steps including the ten presented here the biblical basis establishes the foundation. In the missiological decision of the mission leaders gathered in 1982 designed to help bring clarity and definition to the remaining or unfinished missionary task it can be assumed that those gathered came to their conclusion after serious consideration of the biblical basis.

Step 1: A Biblical Foundation (Figure 1)

Reflections from Scriptures on mission from Genesis to Revelation provide the foundation upon which to build the framework. The Bible informs us about the ways of God in mission (the *missio Dei*). Not everyone committed to this basic framework agrees with the sequence of the steps. Missiologists Verkuyl and Bosch would place the history of the study of mission before the biblical foundation. Bosch presented an overview of the ways in which the church, down through the centuries, has understood her missionary responsibility before dealing with the biblical foundations (Bosch 1993).

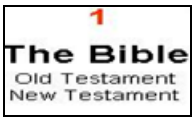


FIGURE 1
THE FIRST AND FOUNDATIONAL DOMAIN OF MISSIOLOGICAL DECISION MAKING

Step 2: The Church's Reflection (Figure 2)

The historical and systematic theological reflection of the church has impacted the various lenses that have been used to look at the Bible and mission through history. An example of this is what Bosch does in *Witness to the World: The Christian Mission in Theological Perspective* (1980). The purpose of the book is to acquaint pastors, missionaries and church members with the problems facing missions today. Bosch presents the crisis of mission in our day as a result, in part, of the overuse and divergent understanding of the word mission itself. The thesis of *Witness to the World* is that the summary question that needs to be addressed in understanding the significant issues in the theology of mission is "What does it mean to be the church of Christ in the world today?" In approaching this question, Bosch deals with the theology of mission through the ages. He reviews the historical perspective of mission of the early church, the Constantinian era, from Alexander VI to Pius XII, from Martin Luther to Martin Kähler, from John Eliot to John Mott, Ecumenical Missionary Theology and developments since 1960 (Bosch 1980:93-182).

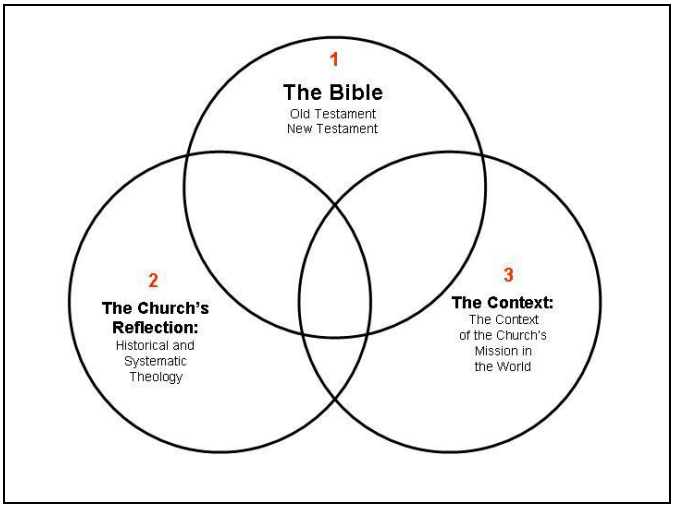


FIGURE 2

THREE DOMAINS OF MISSIOLOGY

Step 3: The World Context (Figure 2)

In each unique context, mission takes place and shapes the evolving understanding of mission. An example of this process is in *Christ Outside the Gate* (Costas 1982). Orlando Costas writes essays that "demonstrate the contextual character of missiology as 'a theology of the crossroads,' or a critical reflection at the point where cultures, ideologies, religious traditions, and social, economic and political systems confront each other, and where the gospel seeks to cross the frontier of unbelief" (Costas 1982:xiv).

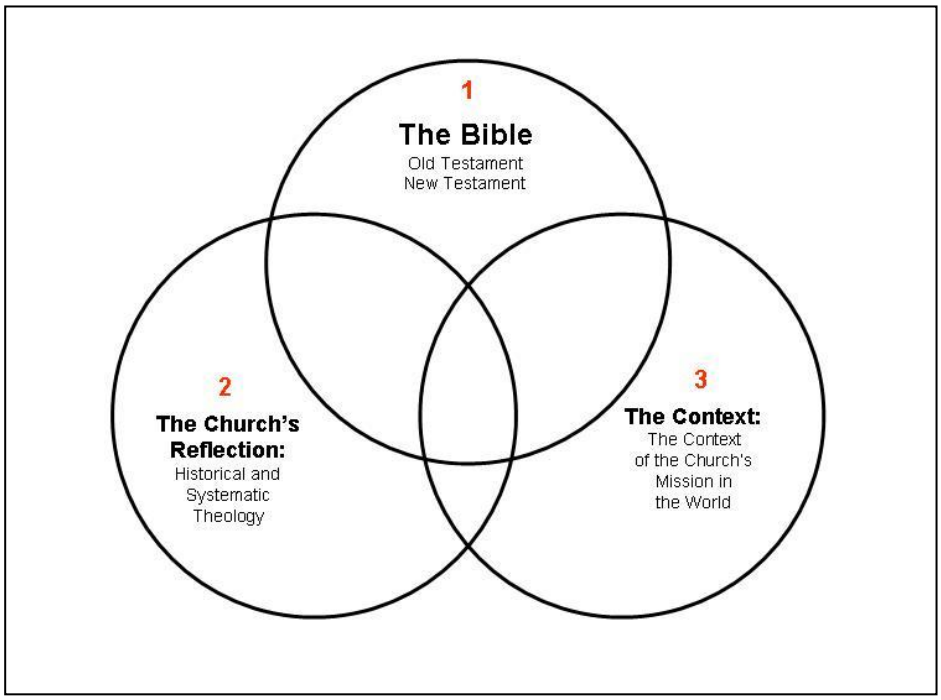


FIGURE 2

THREE DOMAINS OF MISSIOLOGY

The three-arena nature of missiology has served as a framework for deliberations on mission for a number of missiologists as well as training centers, including Fuller Theological Seminary School of World Mission. Leonardo Boff, Orlando Costas, David Bosch, Johannes Verkuyl, John V. Taylor,

Donald McGavran, Max Warren, Leslie Newbigin, James Scherer, Gerald Anderson, Carl Braaten, Howard Snyder, Jürgen Moltmann, among others "also utilize a three-arena approach in their theology and missiology, though they may not speak of all three at once in the same place" (Van Engen 2001a).

In Figure 2, each domain represents a sphere of knowledge, influence, activity and relationship. Each circle thus symbolizes a domain of missiology that provides a unique contribution for mission. The overlap of multiple circles represents a level of integration and continuity in multiple domains.

Step 4: Personal Experience: The Four Domains (Figure 2)

Each of us who approach the Bible and examine the story of God's mission bring his or her own set of cultural and personal strengths, weaknesses, and pilgrimage. These affect the way in which Scripture and mission is understood and perceived. The Bible, the church, the context, and God's mission are all seen through one's own personal lens. Every individual brings to the missional task their cultural background, personal pilgrimage, spirituality and family.

The personal pilgrimage and one's own experience of the cross and growth in spirituality will, of course, provide a major creative addition to the multi-faceted interactive missiological framework. Together, the four circles represent the fundamental components of the frame for missional action. When we read the narratives of God's mission through people in the Bible, we find all four of these domains are experienced simultaneously, and each Christian worker will probably want to take stock of his or her own life and purpose, particularly in context of Circles 1, 2, 3.

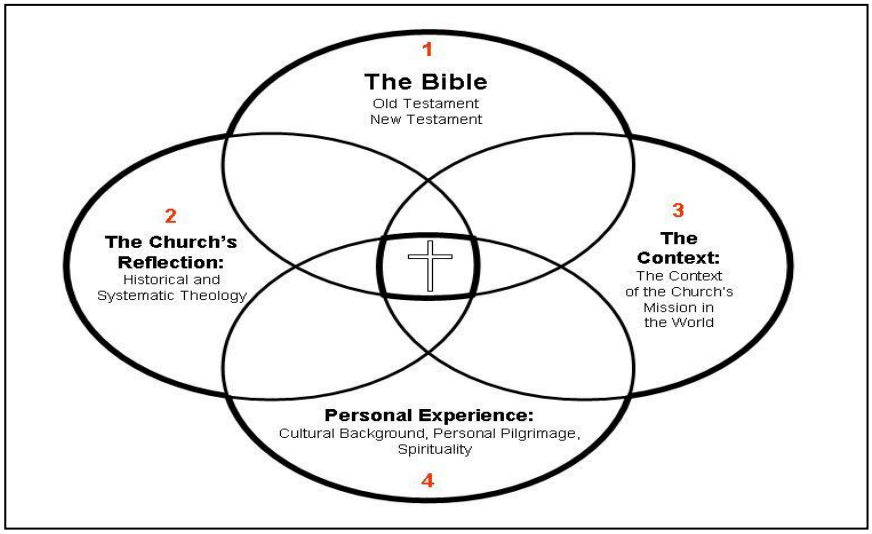


FIGURE 2

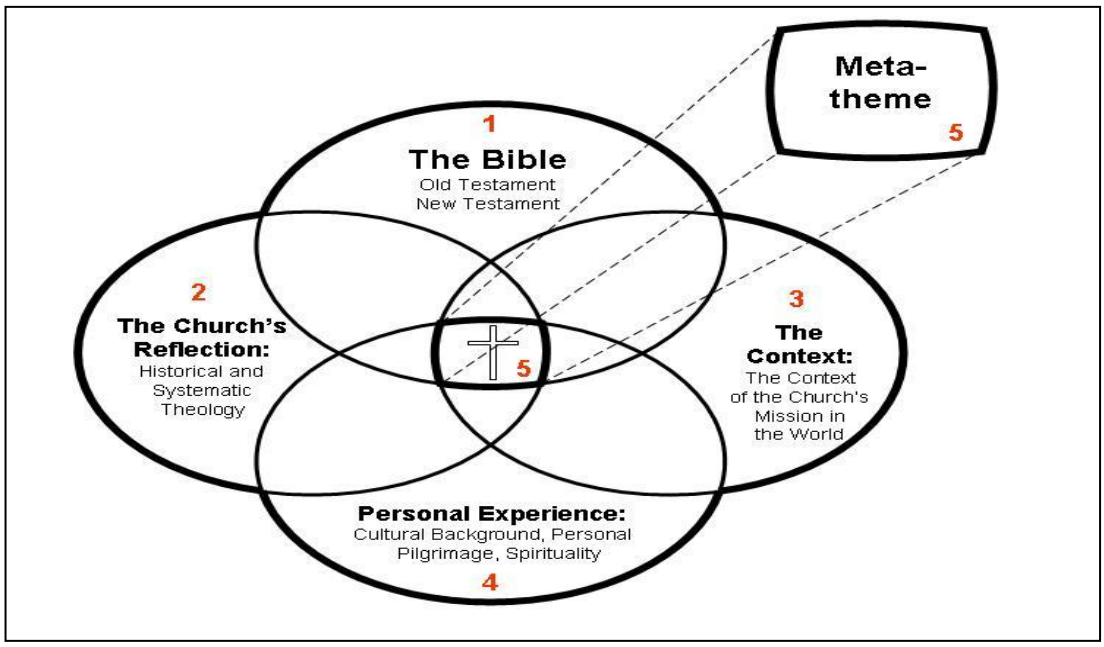
PERSONAL EXPERIENCE:
THE FOUR DOMAINS

Step 5: The Integrating Idea/Meta-Theme of Mission (Figure 3)

It is from the place where all four domains of mission (Bible, Church, Person, and Context) intersect at the cross that they interact and influence each other. The meta-theme contains the motif, integrating idea, unifying paradigm or paradigms, perceptions, and thinking patterns common to all four domains, and occasionally these same terms are interchanged. The meta-theme provides connectivity and continuity between domains:

> Seen in its entirety, the Integrating Idea flows through a process (channel) that transforms it from theory into action. In this process, it is evaluated, examined, enhanced, energized, enacted, and finally reintegrated with the four original domains so that reconceptualization can take place leading towards a refinement of mission. Over time, therefore, this becomes an iterative process that is constantly making adjustments in mission theory and practice (Van Engen 2001a).

One of those who reflected on the concept of an integrating idea in mission was Hendrikus Berkhof. He surveyed the church theologians in his exhaustive treatment of dogmatics. In the process he defined dogmatics as the "scientific reflection on the Christian faith" (Berkhof 1988:45). In relating



dogmatics to mission he introduced the term "theologizing," which was used by missiologists who followed him. Berkhof then equated theologizing to dogmatic reflection (1988:49). What informs theologizing is the Word, the world and the church (1988:78). The process of theologizing needs to have a foundation. "We recall that earlier we talked about the foundations on which theologizing must rest" (1988:73). He observes that "scholars of the day, in pursuit of a timely and relevant theology, embraced themes for mission such as 'revolution,' 'liberation,' and 'emancipation'" (1988:62). One of the experiments in "praxis-based dogmatic reflection" led to liberation theology (1988:49).

What then is an appropriate foundation for theologizing? Berkhof explores various alternatives, primarily, the Scriptures. He concludes that the integrating idea of theologizing in mission should be Jesus Christ. "Christ, after all, rather than exhausting Scripture, is in turn end point, starting point, and center of a long covenantal history." And, "it is natural, then, to declare Christ to be the foundation of dogmatics" (1988:80). The methodological concentration in the process of ascertaining a unifying paradigm for mission should be Christ. The centralization of Christ was mastered by Karl Barth, who talks about proximity to Christ (1988:80).

FIGURE 3

FOUR DOMAINS AND THE INTEGRATING IDEA

Step 6: The Holy Spirit and Prayer in Mission (Figure 4)

Because mission is the action of the Holy Spirit through the agency of the church from Pentecost forward, it is essential for anyone seeking to be involved in mission to prayerfully reflect on the Holy Spirit's role and invite his presence and direction throughout the assessment process leading to missional action. The spiritual dynamic of prayer releases the Holy Spirit to illumine Scripture, to control the process of assessment, to enthuse participants in that process and to give faith to fulfill an emerging paradigm of mission, and lifts reflection from an academic exercise to a spiritual one.

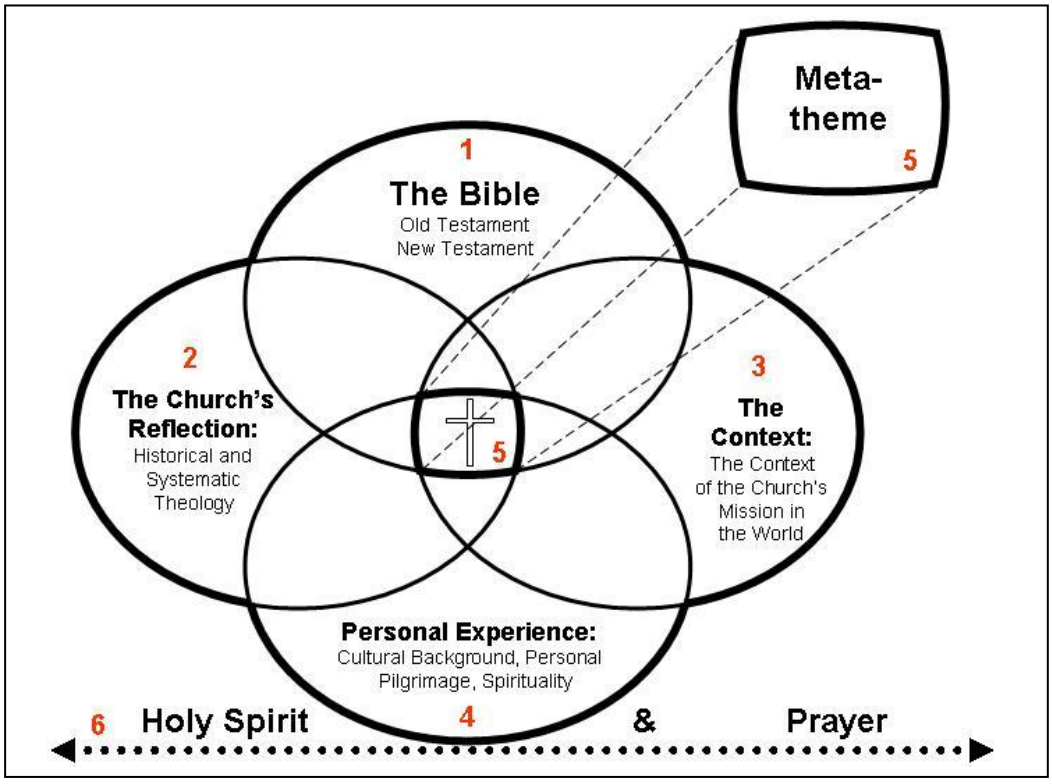


FIGURE 4

THE HOLY SPIRIT AND PRAYER IN MISSION

Step 7: The History of Missional Action (Figure 5)

Everywhere in the world there exists a history of the church's interaction with that context. How has the church conducted its mission? What have been the macro and micro impulses that led to significant mission advance, especially as modeled by the early church?

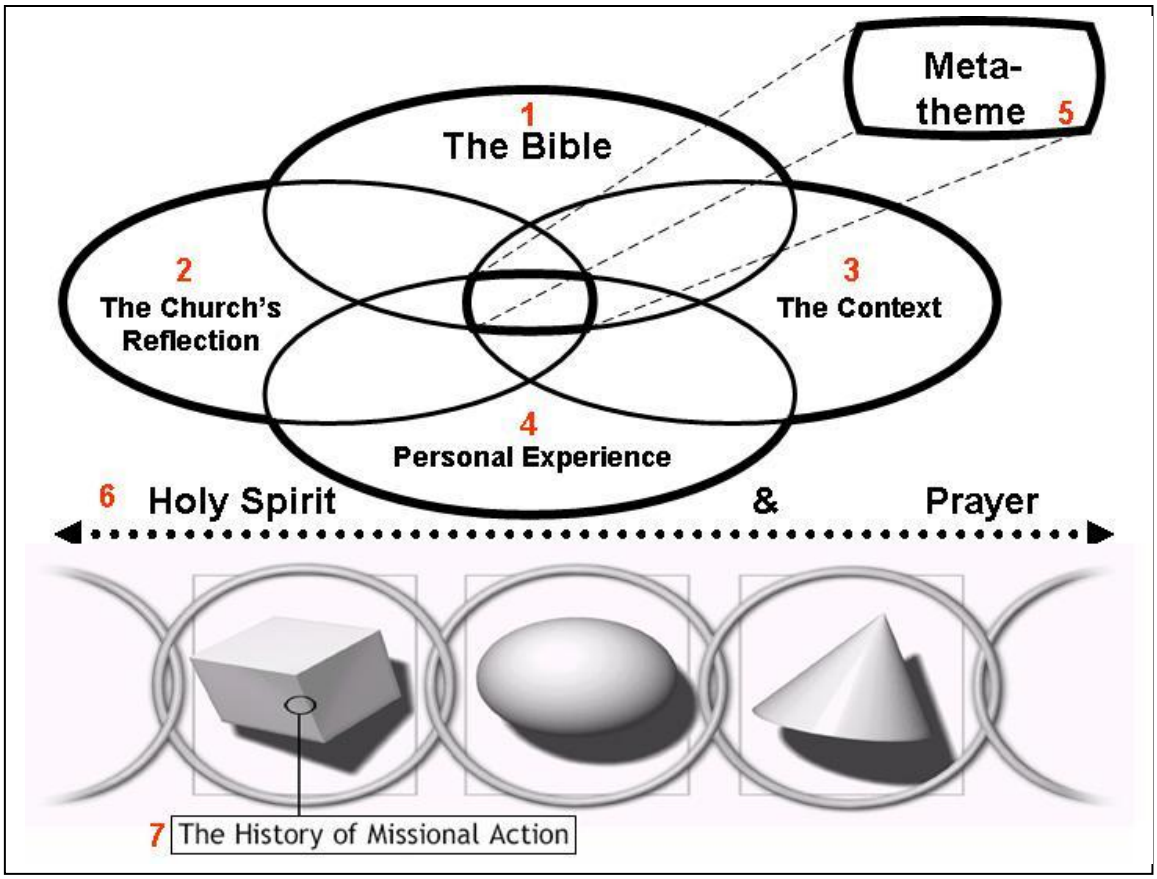


FIGURE 5

HISTORY OF MISSIONAL ACTION

Step 8: The History of Missional Action and Theory (Figure 6)

The particular theological traditions (Ecumenical, Evangelical, Pentecostal, Charismatic, Orthodox, Roman Catholic) have influenced the theoretical framework that has informed mission action.

Mission theory associated with the action is this history of theory that will help guide us (Van Engen 2001a).

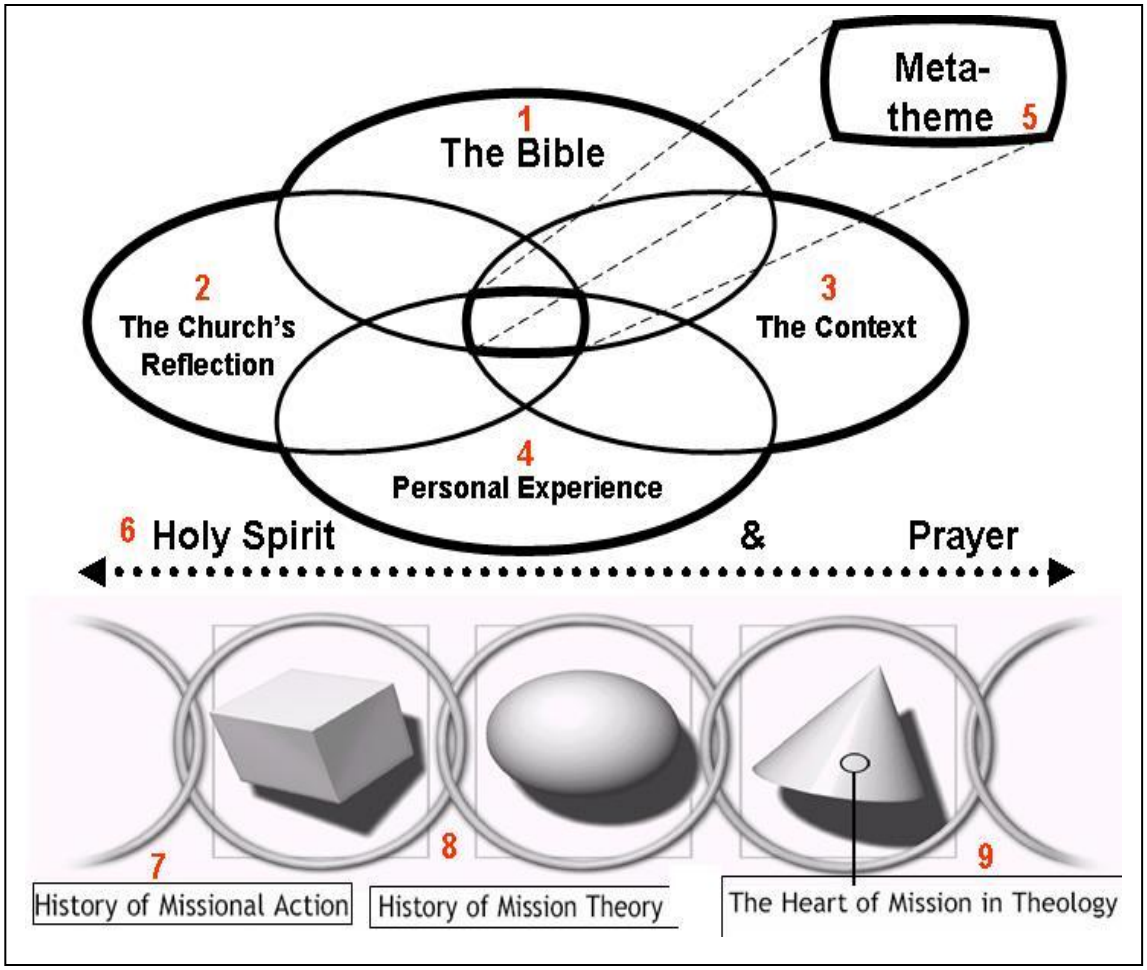


FIGURE 6

HISTORY OF MISSIONAL ACTION AND THEORY

Step 9: The Heart of Mission in *Missio Dei* (Figure 7)

This is where we move from the past to the future (see the Working Grid of Mission, Table 1). In this integrative step, focus the reflection on issues of mission practice. Work through the matrix of foundational categories of mission theory with attendant aspects of missional action.

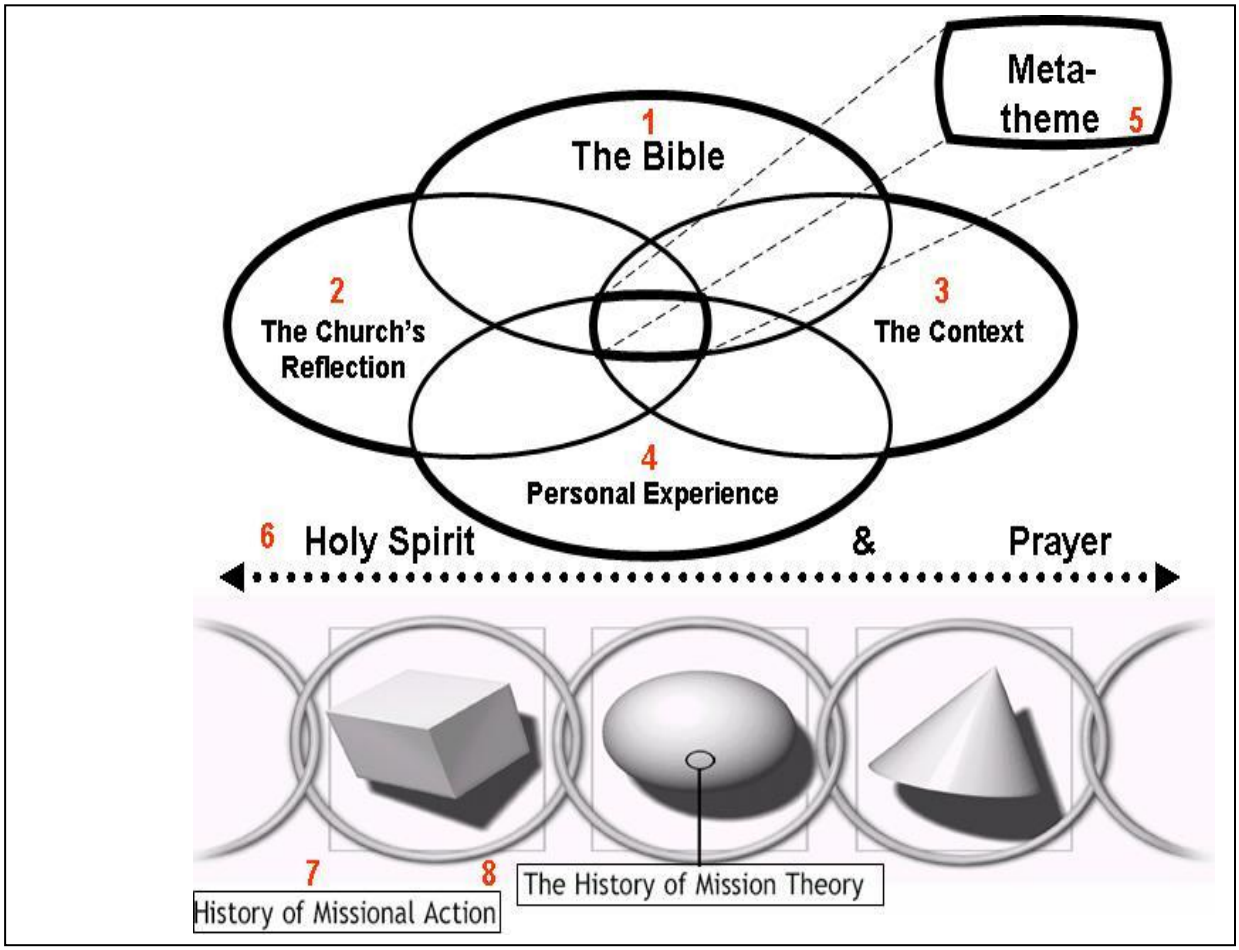


FIGURE 7

THE HEART OF MISSION IN *MISSIO DEI*

Figure 7 links the preceding steps in the missional framework with the steps that follow, as part of an integrative and yet closely interconnected methodological process. It is the interweaving of the vertical aspects of mission with the horizontal where the grid can be most helpful and, at the same time, most complex.

TABLE 1

WORKING GRID OF MISSION
(Adapted from Van Engen 1996:29)

Aspects of Mission	*Missio Dei*	*Missio Christi*	*Missio Spiritus Sancti*	*Missio Hominum*	*Missiones Ecclesia-rum*	*Missio Politica Oecume-nica*	*Missio Futurum/ Adventus*
Missio Spiritus Sancti							
Mission Context							
Agents of Mission							
Motives of Mission							
Means of Mission							
Methods of Mission							
Goals of Mission							
Results of Mission							
Centripetal/ Centrifugal Activities							
Utopia/Future Hope							
Presence							
Proclamation							
Persuasion							
Incorporation							
Structures							
Partnerships							
Power							
Prayer							
Praise							
Other?							

Step 10: The Missional Action (Figure 8)

Missional action or praxis is defined based on the integration offered in the grid, relating church and context in a specific time and place. Other important considerations include what resources are available for the task and where they are working at the current time.

Over time, the action informs reflection as the reflection has informed the action. Theory informs praxis and, in turn, praxis informs theory. The final phase of missional action calls for reflection on the action which then launches the process of assessment all over again:

> Reflection, re-examination, re-thinking, and reconceptualizing are needed at this point. Reflection should take place addressing the consistency between the action taken and the initial conceptualization found in the integrating idea. Where are anomalies, inconsistencies, and contradictions between the understanding of the integrating idea and the action taken, we must look more carefully. The place of anomalies is the place where reconceptualization begins all over again. This creates a process of action and reflection which is molded through time (Van Engen 2001a).

The process will change personal experience. A major change can then result in a paradigm shift.

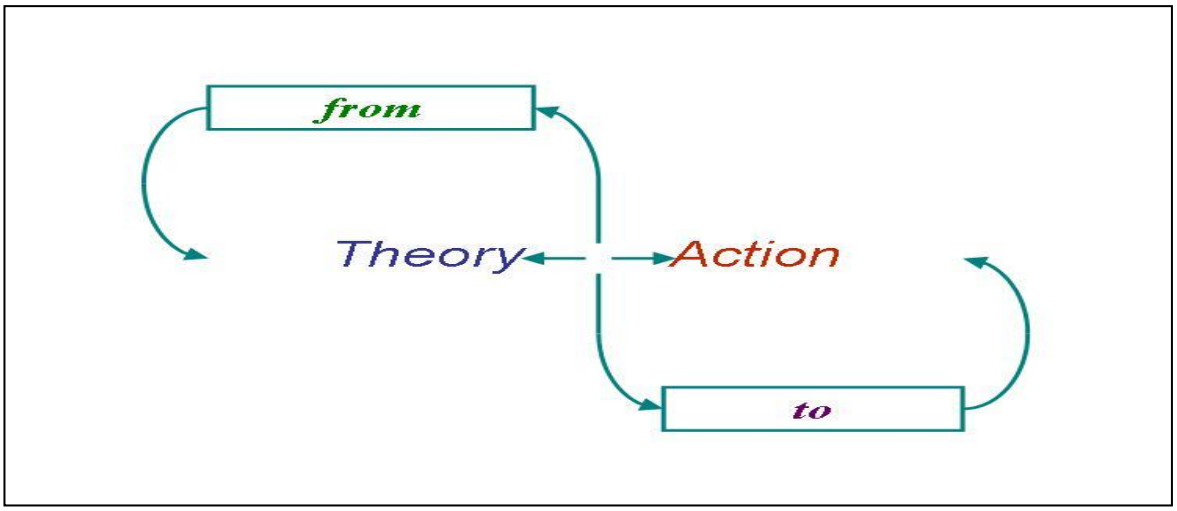


FIGURE 8

MISSIONAL ACTION

Conclusion

From time to time, the stakeholders in churches, mission agencies, national initiatives, global structures and movements evaluate the results of the mission they are seeking to carry out. In these early days of the twenty-first century and third millennium, it is an appropriate moment to conduct a thorough

assessment, not only of the results of the mission we are carrying out, but the very nature of the mission objectives.

The process of evaluation outlined above can be applied to local churches, denominations, networks, mission structures and/or mission movements. The hoped-for outcome is to arrive at a catalytic impetus that a methodological review of our missional action can have on world evangelization in the twenty-first century, but there is no guarantee that this outcome will, in fact, occur.

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